Wai'anae Summit Trail Traverse

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Abstract

The Wai'anae Summit Trail (WST) is 26 miles long with 12,300 ft of total elevation gain, and stretches from Ka'ena Point to Makakilo on the island of Oahu in Hawaii. I finished the WST in 20 hours and 44 minutes both solo and unsupported after a sleepless night, extreme dehydration, fatigue, and hallucinations. The trail was far more overgrown than expected, and presented a more formidable challenge than I could've ever imagined.

1 Introduction

There are two mountain ranges on the island of Oahu: The Ko'olau mountain range and the Wai'anae mountain range. They were formed by volcanic activity millions of years ago, each representing a separate shield volcano that erupted and built up over time. There is a trail that traverses each of these mountain ranges, but both trails are not well maintained, partially illegal, and require walking/crawling on narrow sections of the ridgeline, where slipping can result in a drop off a cliff that can cause serious injury or death. Very few people have ever traversed across these dangerous ridges.

The Wai'anae mountain range is the older of the two mountain ranges, formed by the Wai'anae Volcano. This shield volcano began its eruptive activity around 3.9 million years ago and continued until about 2.5 million years ago. Over time, the eruptions built up a broad, gently sloping shield volcano, typical of Hawaiian volcanoes, with flows of basaltic lava. After the main volcanic activity ceased, the volcano gradually eroded, leaving behind the steep ridges and deep valleys that characterize the range today. It has less than half the length and total elevation gain of the Ko'olau Mountain Range. The Wai'anae Summit Trail (WST) is just 26 miles long with 12,300 ft of total elevation gain, while the Ko'olau Summit Trail (KST) is 56 miles long with over 27,000 ft of elevation gain.

2 Preparation

In the previous summer of 2023, I completed the Ko'olau Summit Trail, regarded as the most difficult and treacherous hike on the island of Oahu. It took me about 3 years of planning and training to figure out where my water sources were, what gear I needed, where I could camp, and how long it would take me to hike from each camp/watersite to the next. I knew that I had to become extremely comfortable on the KST, so I did my research and hiked every section of it individually before attempting to do it all in one-shot. Eventually, I completed the KST in one-shot both solo and unsupported, which was the one of the significant physical and mental challenges of my life. After completing the KST, it seemed like a natural next challenge to hike the only other mountain range on the island, so I started looking into what it would take to hike the WST. The WST is a shorter trail that is hotter and drier than the KST, but it features higher peaks and a much more overgrown trail.

Having already completing the KST, I was confident that the WST, being the second hardest hike on the island, would be well within my limits. However, this confidence would ultimately be my downfall and would cause me to do much less preparation than I did for my KST traverse. Unlike the KST, where I spent years



Figure 1: A map of the WST route in red, located on the leeward side of Oahu.



Figure 2: A photo with my parents at the Makapu'u Lighthouse after finishing the KST in 3 days, 9 hours, and 21 minutes



Figure 3: The Chimney - One of the climbing features along the KST. Photo: Sho Heskett



Figure 4: All smiles on the first look at the WST with Luke Kaminskas. Photo: Sho Heskett

hiking all of the individual sections to get comfortable with the trail, the first time I ever stepped foot on the WST was one week before attempting to do a one-shot traverse. I covered about half a mile on the WST during that brief hike, where I went up the Kealia Trail with my friends Sho Heskett and Luke Kaminskas, and we walked north for half a mile on one of the most pristine sections of the trail before turning around and heading back down. This part of the trail was well maintained and easy to follow, which I would soon realize was not the norm on the WST.

I wanted to hike the whole WST in sections so that I was well prepared before my one-shot attempt, but it didn't end up happening in the end. A couple days after finishing the KST, I left home and flew to San Diego to go back to college at UCSD. It was around a month later that I got the idea in my head that I wanted to hike the WST. I figured that the following summer would be a good time to do it, however, I was going to be away from Oahu for a long time before coming back for the summer. When I eventually returned home for the summer, I only gave myself a 3 week time window before I had to go back to San Diego for school again. I got caught up with surfing and doing other hikes in the Ko'olaus, so I didn't end up doing much hiking on the WST before the end of my time window. Although I didn't get much preparation done, I still wanted to give the WST a shot, so I decided to go for it anyways.

3 Gear

Total pack weight with 5.5L of water: 18.8 pounds. Pretty heavy pack for a one-day hike in my opinion, but most of it was water weight.

- Camelbak MULE Hydration Pack. This is a small lightweight pack that my mom originally bought around 10 years ago and used for a bit before handing it down to me. Although it is very old, it still holds up well and I had no complaints with it.
- Columbia Men's Watertight II Rain Jacket: Cheap, lightweight rain jacket. It didn't rain, so I never ended up using it and it became dead-weight.



Figure 5: Putting the Florence Marine X gear to the test. This gear is tough! Photo: Sho Heskett



Figure 6: The gear I used to get me through 24 hours of hiking with no sleep

- Florence Marine X Adapt Long Sleeve Hooded UPF Shirt - Heather Black: Perfect for keeping the sun off me while also keeping my arms from getting scratched up by branches along the trail. Long sleeves are absolutely necessary for this trail.
- Showa Atlas 300 Gloves Size L: Gloves are necessary for pulling yourself through the overgrowth of the trail. Even with these gloves on, I still had tons of small cuts all over my hands from the thorny plants. By the end of the trail, these gloves were ripped to shreds. Time for a new pair.
- Patagonia Trail Pants: Lightweight, breathable, and stretchy. They had a few tears by the end of the trail, and I still ended up getting cuts on my legs from the thorns.
- 1 Pair of Innotree Men's Large Hiking Socks: 50% Cotton, 45% nylon, 5% Lycra spandex. Still ended up getting 4-5 blisters on each foot, but I don't think any sock would've prevented that. Blisters seem to be inevitable when hiking the WST. My feet got wet at the beginning and stayed wet the whole time while walking on uneven ground - the perfect recipe for large blisters.
- Salomon Speedcross 5 Gore-Tex Shoes: I haven't tried many other pairs of hiking shoes, but these seem to do the trick for me. They are light and have the perfect combination of grip and comfort.
- 3L Camelbak Water Reservoir: Nice to be able to sip water without having to take your pack off, but

difficult to monitor water consumption without being able to actually see the water level inside your bag.

- 1.5L + 1L Whole Foods 365 Water Bottles: Light water bottles to supplement my Camelbak Water Reservoir. I wish I only brought the 1L bottle to reduce weight and then also brought a water filter so that I could filter water from catchment systems along the way instead of only relying off of the water that I brought with me.
- Black Diamond Cosmo 300 Headlamp: There was a full moon, but I found this to be an essential item for night hiking.
- Mregb Solar Powered Portable Charger: Provided more than enough power to charge my phone throughout the whole trip, but it was pretty heavy. Definitely could've gone with a lighter charger.
- iPhone SE/lightning charging cord: Essential for communicating my safety with the outside world as well as for logging my route and navigation. Should have gotten a waterproof case.
- CeraVe Hydrating Mineral Sunscreen: SPF 50, reef safe, mineral sunscreen
- John Muir College Sunglasses: Protected my eyes from the sun - courtesy of UCSD freshman orientation day.
- Florence Marine X Airtex Boonie - Burnt Olive Camo: Kept my face from getting too sunburned and stayed on my head the whole time with the chin strap.
- GoPro with Headstrap: Wanted to take videos to document the trip, but I was so exhausted and delirious that I didn't end up filming much.

4 Food

I brought a total of 3,720 calories. My food supply consisted of 6 Crunchy Peanut Butter Clif Bars, 6 Chocolate Chip Clif Bars, 1 Chocolate Peanut Butter Clif Builders Protein Bar, 1 Chocolate Mint Clif Builders Protein Bar, 1 Yuzu Pineapple Liquid IV Packet, and 1 Strawberry Liquid IV Packet. I ended up eating all of the food except for 2 Crunchy Peanut Butter Clif Bars and 2 Chocolate Chip Clif Bars. I would've liked to have consumed more calories on the hike, but as soon as I ran out of water and became dehydrated, it became impossible to stuff a dry Clif bar down my throat.

5 Plan

I had planned to start the hike on Saturday, August 24th and roughly follow the same time schedule as the fastest known time (FKT) set by Nandor Szotak, Dylan Cotton, and Rozie Breslin, where they started the trail at midnight and finished 17h 30min 32s later, before the sun set. Suffice to say, things did not go as planned.

6 Mission

Ka'ena Point to Mount Ka'ala - 13 miles, 5h 54m My plans to hike the WST on the weekend were thwarted when tropical storm Hone and hurricane Gilma formed in the Pacific and were set to bring stormy conditions to Oahu over my planned hiking time. I ended up starting the hike a few days early, on the night of Tuesday, August 20th to avoid the bad weather and give myself plenty of time to get out of the mountains before the storms hit Hawaii. I decided on the morning of the hike that I was going to do it that day, so it was a bit of a scramble to get my rides setup to and from trailheads and my gear prepared. There was also a nice south swell running, so I went for a morning surf at Ala Moana Bowls before prepping for the

journey ahead of me. Of course I ended up getting a 3 inch slice on the top of my right foot courtesy of the sharp reef after pulling into a closeout barrel, but I decided that the cut was minor enough that I could still continue with my plans to hike the WST. I anxiously awaited until the evening for my hike to begin. I wanted to try and sleep during the day so that I wasn't so sleep deprived at night while I was on the trail, but I was only able to get about 1 hour of sleep in. I was far too nervous to sleep for any longer. My friends Joe Ruszkowski and Puna Smith picked me up in town at 9:30pm and drove me up to the gate at Ka'ena Point. We said our farewells and I started the 3 mile trek out to the end of Ka'ena Point at around 10:30pm. It was a beautiful evening with a full moon and no one else around. The moon was so bright that I didn't even use my headlamp while hiking to the start of the WST. Although it was a clear and serene night, it was also a little eerie because I began to hear noises that sounded like a baby crying as I was walking along. I thought to myself, "there's no way that there is a baby all alone crying out here in the middle of the night," and I continued on. I knew that it was just the sound of the wedge-tailed shearwaters, which are known to make calling sounds that sound like a baby crying. Ka'ena Point is a protected bird sanctuary where there are a ton of wedge-tailed shearwaters around, so I assured myself that it was just the sound of the birds and tried to push it out of my mind to focus on the trail ahead of me.

After 3 miles of walking along the flat trail out to the end of Ka'ena Point, I reached the start of the WST, which is just a very small trail through the tall grass leading up to the Wai'anae Mountain Range, away from the water. I began weaving my way through the windy and steep trail up the mountain, passing a couple of old military bunkers along the way. I kept climbing in elevation until I reached a barbed wire fence that blocked the path. I won't go into too much detail, but that fence is to keep people out of the Space Force Satellite Tracking Station. Let's just say that I definitely did not trespass onto the base and I definitely obeyed all the laws to pass through this section of the WST legally. I saw a couple of cows, a couple of wild boars, and no other humans around. Fast forward a couple of miles and I'm back on the Kuaokala section of the trail. The trail is nice and wide, not too steep, ironwood trees all around, and is composed of packed dirt - easy to walk on. At this point, I'm having a great time. My spirits are high and I'm moving fast - between 3 and 4 mph. I was thinking to myself, at this rate I'll be done with the trail in 8 or 9 hours. Of course, my naive unprepared self who was unfamiliar with the rest of the trail was badly mistaken. It would take me well over double that amount of time to finish the WST in the end. However, I digress. I passed through the one section of the trail that I was familiar with, the half a mile of the WST just north of the Kealia summit that was beautifully groomed and well maintained. After I passed through the Kealia summit, I encountered my first bit of overgrowth. The trail became much narrower and I quickly slowed down to a snail's pace as I fought through the various branches, leaves, and thorns that were scratching at every part of my body with each step. The worst part was the never ending invasive Himalayan Blackberry bushes with thorns that would poke into me like thumbtacks with each step forward. The thorns were commonplace throughout the rest of the overgrown parts of the trail. Thankfully, this overgrown section only lasted a short while and I was back onto a proper trail in no time. Unfazed, I continued on, but looking back on it, I now see that this was just a taste of the overgrown trail that was to come.

I kept zipping through the trail in the dark, around 1-2am in the morning with excitement and adrenaline keeping me awake, even though I'm normally fast asleep by 9pm. I passed Peacock Flats soon enough and then started to encounter an extremely overgrown section of the trail. I could see Mt. Ka'ala way off in the distance and my goal was to get there before sunrise. I followed along the fence that runs throughout much of the WST, but there wasn't much of a trail at all along it. It looked like no one had stepped foot on this section of the trail in a very long time. The plants had completely taken over the trail and grown straight over it. My pace dropped to around 1 mph and I began bushwhacking through the overgrowth. Every step was painful and required my full effort to push through branches and pull thorns out of my arms, legs, chest, and back. I also took about 50 Happy-Face Spider webs to the face - thankfully I'm not too bothered by spiders. At one point I lost the trail and wandered around for a few minutes. Eventually I saw the back of a sign on top of the hill above me and worked my way back up to it. When I got to the top of the hill, I found the trail again and looked at the front of the sign. The sign read "DO NOT ENTER HIGH EXPLOSIVES IMPACT AREA SHELLS AND OTHER OBJECTS MAY EXPLODE IF TOUCHED OR MOVED." Of course the sign was referring to the area that I just got lost in. Thankfully I did not step on any unexploded



Figure 7: Ready for action. Photo: Sho Heskett

ordnances, but this sign struck fear into my heart and I'm lucky that things turned out all right.

I continued on, shook from my near encounter with possible landmines. The trail only got more and more overgrown until I could finally see the US Army maintained road that led up to the top of Mount Ka'ala. Again, I definitely did not tresspass onto military property at this point and definitely did not do anything illegal here. Let's fast forward now to the top of Mount Ka'ala. I finally made it to the tallest point on the island, 4,025 ft above sea level. It was pretty cold and socked in by clouds. It was still dark and I had another 30 minutes before sunrise. I was on schedule so far despite the trail being more overgrown than expected.

Mount Ka'ala to Pu'u Hapapa - 7 miles, 7h 30m The landscape on top of Mount Ka'ala is truly breathtaking and unique. It is essentially a large flat bog at the top. It's muddy and moist, but there's so much plant life all around. There's a boardwalk that goes through most of the bog and eventually leads to the trail that goes back down the mountains to Wai'anae, but I had to step off the boardwalk early and trudge through the muddy bog to continue on the WST. This part was quite tricky. There wasn't much of a trail to follow and I couldn't see any landmarks around me because of the dense, overhead foliage and heavy cloud cover. There were a couple of blue trail markers that I followed, but I soon became lost and confused, mostly just trying to follow the GPS tracks on my phone in the right direction. At some point I accidentally wandered between two trees where someone had setup a tripwire/snare for a wild boar. I didn't see the tripwire until it was too late and I had already triggered it. The wire snapped tight around my right leg and I was soon stuck in place. This was one of the most frightening parts of the trail for me because I didn't know if I would be able to free myself. I was stuck off trail in one of the most remote parts of the island. I really wish I had brought a knife so that I could've cut the wire, but I decided not to include it on my packing list so that I could reduce weight in my pack. Regardless, I needed to find a way to free myself



Figure 8: One of the few areas on the island where you can accidentally step on an old military unexploded ordnance. Fortunately, no explosives were set off this time around.



Figure 9: This is the trail! Do you see it? I don't...

from this snare. I looked at it and saw that it had a locking mechanism on it that was keeping me trapped, but it looked rusty and weak enough that I might be able to break it with enough effort. I started yanking at the wire to break the locking mechanism, and after several minutes of huffing and puffing, I broke it and was able to get my leg free. What a relief! Now back to the trail.

I made it across the Ka'ala bog and began my descent down the peak to continue along the WST. Of course I got lost again. I knew that I had to continue down the ridge, but there was no trail to follow. I tried several different approaches including crawling under branches, contouring the side of the cliff, and pushing through the dense overgrowth, but I was unable to pass the section. I must've been stuck in this one spot for about 45 minutes before I eventually went berserk and smashed through a bunch of invasive plants to finally make it down to a slightly more manageable part of the trail that I could pass through. This next part was also pretty sketchy because it was wet, slippery, mossy, and required some rappelling with some old frayed ropes. I took it slow and steady and eventually maneuvered my way past the ropes section and across the Pu'u Kalena Trail up to Pu'u Kumakali'i, where I could look down into Kolekole Pass - the deepest saddle along the WST with the most elevation loss and gain in the shortest amount of time.

At the bottom of Kolekole pass is the only road the passes through the Wai'anae Mountain Range, connecting central Oahu to the west side of the island. However, this road is owned by the US Army and requires military access for usage. Once again, I definitely did not trespass on military property and definitely did not walk on this road at all. On the way down to the bottom of Kolekole pass fro Pu'u Kumakali'i, I got lost another 10 times. At this point, it was mid-morning and the sun had dried up all of the morning dew. I was out of the clouds and could see everything around me, but there just wasn't much of a trail to follow - a common theme of the WST. After making many wrong turns, I finally made it to the bottom of Kolekole pass and began the brutal uphill climb up to Pu'u Hapapa. The sun was blazing hot now - probably around 90° and I gained about 1,400 ft of elevation in an extremely short amount of time. Needless to say, I was drinking more water than a dog on a hot summer day. This is where the biggest of my problems started. I had only brought 5.5L of water and I only had 0.5L of water left after getting to the summit of Pu'u Hapapa. With over 7 hours of hiking time left in the scorching sun, I knew that I was in trouble. I was under the

impression that the WST didn't have any water sources where I could filter water from because it was just too dry and hot on the west side of the island, but at the top of Pu'u Hapapa I found a water catchment system that the military had set up. If only I had brought a water filter! I could've saved myself so much pain and suffering.



Figure 10: Most of the WST requires following along this fence. Unfortunately, in most places there's not much of a trail to go along with the fence.

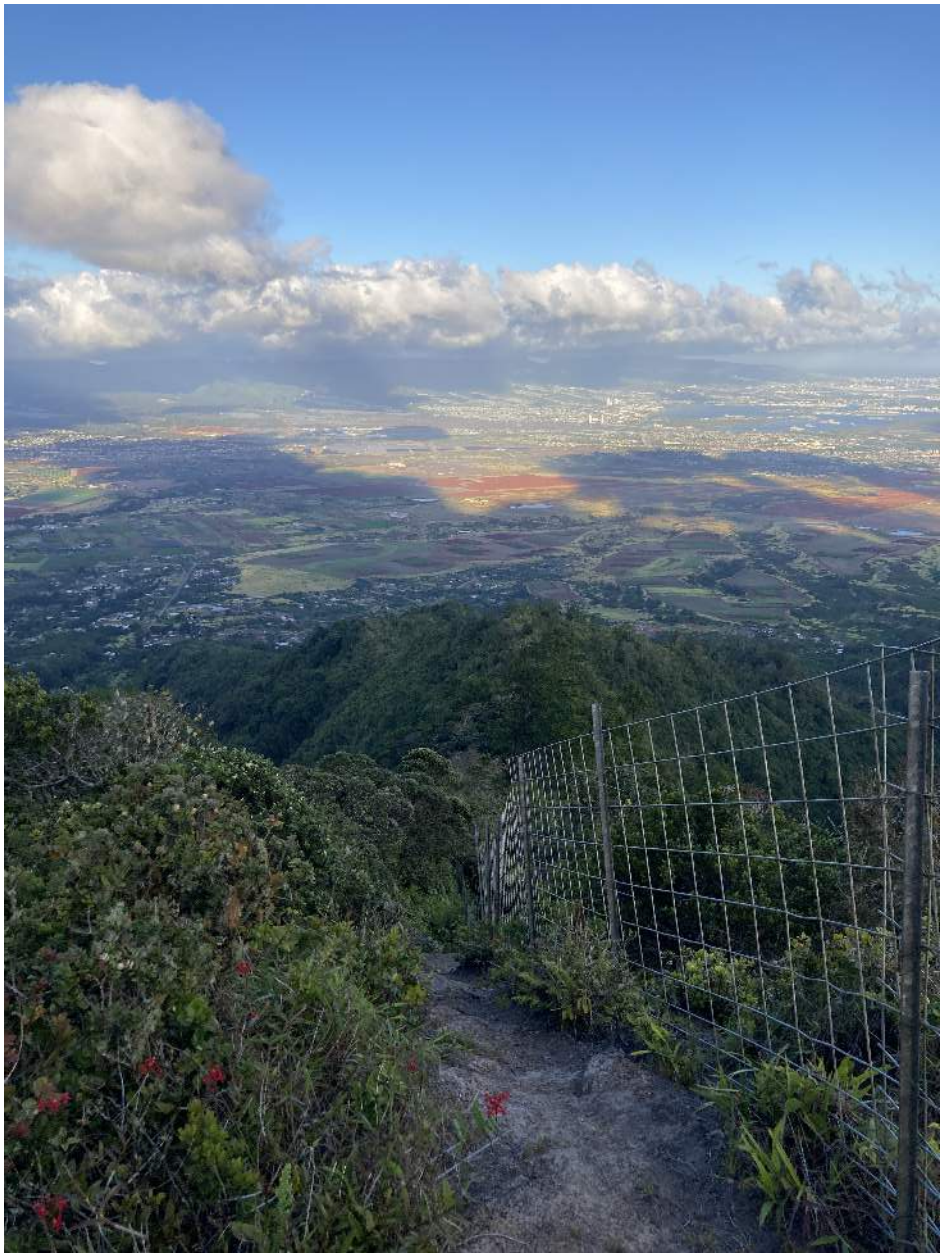


Figure 11: The fence is everywhere! Beautiful view of the center of the island and Pearl Harbor.



Figure 12: A view of Lualualei Valley on the other side of the island.



Figure 13: One of the nicer parts of trail. A great break from the incessant overgrowth.

Pu'u Hapapa to Palehua - 6 miles, 7h 20m With a large chunk of the trail ahead of me, a dwindling water supply, and exhaustion from a night of no sleep and tough hiking, I was beginning to feel fatigued and a bit loopy. I continued along the exposed ridgeline to Pu'u Kanehoa and the infamous Gorilla Heads. The Gorilla Heads are just a couple of somewhat steep scrambles that are really not as hard as people make them out to be. I moved through them pretty quickly, but not before running out of my last bit of water, despite my best efforts to ration. I now had a throbbing headache probably due to dehydration and lack of sleep, muscle cramps, and a brain working at 50% of its normal capacity. Not good. I was concerned that I was going to push my body too hard and pass out on the trail, so I decided to take it slow and take lots of breaks. I told myself the only way I was going to get water and make it off the mountain was by finishing the trail.

It was around this time that things really started to get weird for me. I was beyond exhausted and began fixating my vision on objects like trees or buildings way off in the distance. My vision would unfocus and then refocus again. Eventually I started hallucinating. I remember looking at some branches, having my vision unfocus, and then refocus again and seeing wooden statue tikis staring back at me. I knew that they weren't real, but it was weird because I didn't feel like it was that out of the ordinary at all. I was so loopy that I didn't really even feel like anything was wrong. I also remember seeing a bunch of blue ribbons dance across my field of view. They kind of looked like some of the blue trail markers that I had seen before, except these ones were definitely not real.

With much effort and exhaustion, I finally reached Pu'u Kaua, one of the last peaks before the finish line. I decided to take a rest and call some of my friends for some moral support. Thank you to Luke Kaminskas, Rebecca Jamgochian, and the Ruszkowski family for giving me some words of encouragement while I was in pretty bad shape. I don't know if I would've had the strength to complete the trail otherwise. I came across some old jugs left by the military with the label "Potable Water" on them, so I decided to pour some of the water into one of my water bottles. Water came out with some black particles. I knew that it wasn't safe to drink, but I filtered some water through my shirt and drank a little bit anyways because I figured that it would be better to get hydrated now and get sick later than to remain dehydrated and possibly pass out. The water tasted like dirt and didn't make me feel any better. I only had a couple of sips before abandoning it and moving on.

I knew that I only had one more peak to go - Palikea. After that, it would be pretty much all downhill to the end of the trail. Unfortunately, the section between Pu'u Kaua and Palikea is a long and torturous one, full of plenty of overgrowth and the most difficult climbing section along the WST - Pohakea Pass. My delirious state did not make things easier. I made plenty of wrong turns, took an excessive amount of breaks and made it to Pohakea Pass, a difficult climbing obstacle that sent shivers down my spine. For reference, I would say that this obstacle is harder than "The Chimney," a steep pinnacle of rock along the KST that is tricky to climb. My body was barely functioning at this point, and here I was clinging on to some webbing for dear life. If I slipped and fell, it would surely be fatal. My whole body was shaking, but I made it up safely and laid down on the ground at the top for a good amount of time to calm my nerves. I was almost at the end, but the sun was setting soon. I could see Palikea in the distance and I gained a second wind, determined to make it to the end before dark. Long story short, I did not make it to the end of the trail before dark. I didn't even make it to Palikea before the sun went down.

As the sun set and day turned to night, the hallucinations became more frequent and vivid. I imagined seeing wild animals in the trees: monkeys, penguins, platypuses, you name it. They all creeped along slowly next to me, almost as if they were taunting me as I moved laughably slow. Near the very end, I thought that I saw two people up ahead of me. They looked like a man and a woman - I could hear them laughing and see their silhouettes as they rocked in a hammock between two trees. For some reason I had my headlamp off at this point, so I turned it back on so that it didn't seem like I was creeping up on them. I didn't want to scare them. As I got closer and closer, I soon realized that I was completely seeing and hearing people that weren't there at all. The only thing in front of me was a tree. I was going bonkers.

I trudged on with my headlamp and quickly down the Palehua-Palikea trail in the dark to get to the finish line. My dad picked me up at the end of the trail with food and water, and I was beyond grateful to be off the mountain and back into civilization. We left the trail to go back home at 10:15pm. 23h and 45m

after I had gotten dropped off at the northern end of the KST the previous day. I have always wondered what it would be like to hike for 24 hours straight. I now know what it's like and I can tell you that it is a hellish experience. I would not recommend it.



Figure 14: Just taking things one step at a time.



Figure 15: More fencing...



Figure 16: Don't trust every label you see on a jug. I can tell you from firsthand experience that this water was not potable. The black particles were definitely not safe to drink.

7 Takeaways

I will probably never attempt to do a WST one-shot traverse again, but I have learned some valuable lessons along the way, and have been humbled by the mountains yet again. Before hiking the WST, I felt like I had started to take all the luxuries of modern 21st century life for granted, and I'm glad that I was shocked back into gratitude for simple things like access to clean water.

I finished the hike, but I don't feel completely satisfied with the way I did it. I feel like I just barely got away with completing it, and things could've turned out way worse at many points along the trail. I was too confident going into the hike after already completing the KST the previous summer. The false sense of confidence led me astray. I didn't prepare as much as I should've, and I could've been much safer if I had put in more preparation. The Wai'anae Summit Trail is a beast of a hike and I would not take it lightly.

8 Acknowledgements

I'd like to say thank you to Florence Marine X for providing me with some gear to hike in. Their technical apparel is top notch and held up even in the tough overgrowth, where branches were constantly pulling on my clothing. Thank you to my friends Joe Ruszkowski and Puna Smith for dropping me off at Ka'ena Point to start my hike and to my dad for picking me up at the end of the trail 24 hours later, with some much appreciated food and water. Also thank you to the Ruskowski family, Luke Kaminskas, and Rebecca Jamgochian for some words of encouragement after I had a mental crisis near the end of the trail due to exhaustion and dehydration. A big thank you as well to Sho Heskett for being the one to get me inspired to hike in Hawaii in the first place.

Of course, thank you to everyone who has provided documentation on their hikes through the WST. The blog posts and videos from Nandor Szotak, Noah Lang and Kenji Saito were invaluable resources. Lastly, I appreciate every person who has gone up on the WST to set up ropes, clear some of the overgrowth, and place trail markers.

9 Disclaimer

I do not recommend hiking this trail. I wouldn't even really call it a trail because in many places the trail seems to have disappeared - lost to the overgrowth of native and invasive plants. There are also several segments of the trail that are illegal and other segments that are extremely dangerous for even the most experienced hikers. This is not a trail that you can just come to Hawaii on vacation to hike. If you are still determined to hike it, do each section separately and become extremely comfortable with each part before ever attempting to do it all in one-shot.